

12.3 Adobe Lightroom

Adobe Photoshop, the industry standard for photoediting lacks one major feature that competing image editors have, which is a library for sorting, organising and managing photos. This gap is filled in by a software called Lightroom by Adobe, which is a very powerful photo manager. Lightroom is a non-destructive photo editor, like Picasa. The changes made to the photograph do not alter the actual photograph, but will be used for all practical purposes by the software, including exporting the amped up negative to Photoshop for further image editing.

The software has five modules for handling photos. The library module is useful for managing a large database of images. The image database is called a catalogue within the software, and instead of indexing all the photos on the system, which is the most common approach for the software, you can choose to bunch particular types of photos together into catalogues. This could be photos from a particular camera, photos from the web or any other source. You can also mix and match to create a number of catalogues with photos shared between them. There are powerful tagging features, which includes a colour code, ratings, flags, keywords and metadata. You can use these as filters for sorting your photos. A pane on the right allows for basic image editing, like exposure, tone and vibrance in Lightroom 2. You can also create custom filters and use keywords.

The develop module brings up more image retouching tools. These include cropping, red-eye reduction, spot removal and adjustments. You can also correct the exposure, fill light and other image properties of the photograph. There are drop-down boxes for advanced options such as tone curve, split toning and detail. The slideshow module lets you create elaborate slideshows, with transitions and timings, and lets you view or save them. The photos need not occupy the entire frame, and the slideshow features here are vast. The print module lets you process the image for printing. These include borders, margins and orientations. The web module automates a process of creating and exporting HTML or Flash based image galleries for the web. With Picasa around, the regular user may not use this feature, but for professional photographers, or serious hobbyists, this is a great feature to upload photographs on their own